

MCH2075- Popular Culture Media & Identity

Student Number: 200563972

Word count: 1546

I hereby certify that this submission is wholly my own work, and that all quotations and ideas from primary or secondary sources have been acknowledged. I have read the section on Plagiarism in the Programme Handbook *and* completed the Head of Learning & Teaching's Introduction to Academic Integrity (on the Canvas site for my degree programme), and I understand that plagiarism and other unacknowledged debts will be penalised and may lead to failure in this assessment and in the degree.

Critical Analysis Case Study: Japanese anime culture - Otaku and Hentai subculture

The decade of the 2000s served as a foundation for the growth of anime culture, also known as ACGN culture. This was a time when ACGN culture was at its most influential, but it was also just beginning to emerge as a distinct subculture. The internet had rapid and significant growth in popularity throughout this decade. People from all over the world are now able to contribute to the growth of ACGN culture as a result of the proliferation of the internet, which has made the world a more connected place. There is undeniably a component of Japanese culture in ACGN, seeing as how Japan is one of the major birthplaces of ACGN culture and one of the primary raw powerhouses in the evolution of ACGN. On the other hand, there is no question that the culture of Japan is in no way exceptional. The cultures of Europe, America, and Asia, including other areas of China, are also highly significant to ACGN culture and play an essential role in it.

How is anime culture became Pop Culture? It was in 1963 when this pinocchio-like robot with a heart of gold was a major hit in Japan, known as "Astro Boy". It was created by the talented manga artist Osamu Tezuka of NHK, who was responsible for popularising Japanese anime culture in both Japan and the United States. It created a unique anime aesthetic and gave basic form to the emergent anime culture. With the arrival of colour technology in anime, Astro Boy became obsolete due to the monotonous colour difference of black and white, but anime culture was not affected and other anime shows followed in Astro Boy's footsteps and continued to carry anime culture forward, which is how anime culture took shape. The "Golden Age" of Japanese animation was ushered in by the masterpieces crafted by manga artists such as Osamu Tezuka and Hayao Miyazaki. The anime series Dragon Ball Z and Gundam, which kicked off the commercial era, have proven that they are

worthy of passing on the brilliance of their illustrious forebears.



Poster of Astro Boy in US(1963)



Dragon Ball Z poster using full colour technology(1989-1996)

The otaku and hentai subcultures, on the other hand, emerged concurrently with the development of colourful anime and subsequently formed the subculture of anime culture, which has gradually expanded over the course of several decades. According to the findings of Thiam Huat Kam's research, the term "otaku" is used in Japan to refer to specific individuals who are consumers of popular culture. (Kam, 2013)The conventional method for researching otaku is focusing on individuals who partake in particular forms of

consumption without first analysing why these individuals are referred to as "otaku." He proposes that the term "otaku" should be understood as a label; individuals are deemed to be "otaku" either by themselves or by others when they are judged as not following certain rules.(Kam, 2013) The labelling process that was carried out by a group of Japanese university students and the regulations that they invoked are the primary topics discussed in Thiam Huat Kam's article. According to his research of the interviews he conducted with these students, he discovered that in order to decide who is and who is not an otaku, these students utilise four guidelines, which he named the reality rule, the communication rule, the masculinity rule, and the majority rule. The archetype of the otaku appears in nearly every piece of literature that is discussed in the field of literary criticism. As the story moves closer and closer to present times, however, it seems that unfavourable attitudes towards otaku culture are beginning to fade away. Even though there have been many attempts to educate people about the nature of anime, many people still view it as a violent type of art (Borrelli, 2002). In both authors' studies, some negative perceptions of otaku in Japanese society can be found, and the reasons why this is the case are thought-provoking. Unlike the main orientation in anime culture, otaku prefer to watch anime with cute female characters or those with erotic innuendo. This has often led to a society at large that tends to be notoriously prejudiced against the group's subculture and mainstream anime culture. When respondents were asked how familiar they were with anime as a form of animation, a survey that was conducted by Samantha Nicole Inz Chambers discovered that when participants were asked to answer how familiar they were with anime as a style of animation. Only 19.4% of respondents selected "not at all familiar" from the available options for their level of familiarity with anime, which ranged from "extremely familiar" to "very familiar," "pretty familiar" to "very familiar," and "not at all familiar." (Chambers, 2012). 32% of respondents said that they had some previous experience with anime. In response to another question, 40.8% of respondents said that they

would continue to watch anime even if they were now adults. In order to dispel some of the preconceived notions that people have about anime, the participants were given the task of writing down as many adjectives as they could think of that were associated with anime. The researchers zeroed down on seven descriptors that were stated by at least 4% of the people who took part in the study: entertaining, colourful, dramatic, artistic, Japanese, odd, and violent. However, in modern culture, another researcher Borrelli found that other names are being employed to define anime. The phrases "colourful" and "artistic," which were used by survey participants to characterise some of the programmes in the study, provide the impression that anime is perceived more as an art form than as a monotonous, violent picture with no redeeming features. Secondary research also paints a picture of anime as a misunderstood art form. This is especially true when it comes to the misunderstood otaku culture, which is more widespread in the United States than the average American consumer might imagine. The vast majority of news outlets are positive about anime, stating that it offers everyone a form of entertainment that they can enjoy (Borrelli, 2002). That said, according to Borrelli's research, this bias is slowly disappearing over time.



OTAKU: What Japanese People Mean When They Say It

But new questions are coming up about anime culture and otaku, and in the article written by Amy Shirong Lu, the author explores the internationalisation of Japanese anime culture in an effort to help explain the cultural politics that lie behind this pop culture product. This is in response to the fact that new questions are being raised about anime culture and otaku(Lu, 2008). The process of internationalising anime entails the introduction of non-Japanese components into the show's settings, contexts, character designs, and narrative structures(Lu, 2008). The theoretical framework for understanding the internationalisation of anime proposes that there are at least three cultural politics at work behind the international success of anime: firstly, depoliticised internationalisation, which is primarily used as a commercial strategy to attract international audiences; secondly, westernised internationalisation, which satisfies nationalist sentiments; and thirdly, self-directed internationalisation, which reveals a cultural desire to establish a global presence for a particular culture.

For example, the issue mentioned in Sean Leonard's article, otaku and anime fan culture is going global from Japan, but copyright issues are not being addressed, copyright policies are not the same between countries, and Sean Leonard mentions Japanese animation media as a powerful force in the world of alternative entertainment(Leonard, 2005). Despite the abandonment of the American market by Japanese copyright holders, fan persuasion ignited the anime movement in the United States. This historical and cultural analysis suggests that fans' continued copyright infringement between 1976 and 1993 promoted commercial and artistic progress(Leonard, 2005). The increasing number of fan homages that are infringing on the copyrights of the original authors is the problem posed by the fact that otaku and Japanese anime culture are becoming popular culture and even a globalised trend. While it is true that some otaku have no problem creating secondhand works for their favourite works, it is undeniable that such infringements are becoming more and more common, and in some cases have begun to break the law. Some Japanese otaku have even started to make pirated copies, or edit them without the author's permission, in order to share them with otaku in other countries or regions. And this is getting worse in Japanese anime culture, for which Sean Leonard believes it is against the law, but also a symbol of otaku behaviour in general becoming more radical. For me to analysis, this is very true, the behaviour of Japanese otaku is slowly getting out of control and becoming out of hand, with some otaku even physically threatening authors for not making more stories about their favourite characters, and some otaku physically attacking authors because the author or production team's anime doesn't have a satisfying ending.

So, in general, the rise of Japanese anime culture and the otaku subculture is inevitable, and that's not a bad thing. These popular cultures will do good things for Japanese anime, but at the same time, I think the government and anime production companies should guard against and guide these cultures, so that they do not become the opposite of what they were

originally intended to be. This pop culture should not be allowed to develop into a toxic fan culture, which would do more harm than good to Japanese anime and otaku culture itself.

Bibliography

Kam, T.H. (2013) "The common sense that makes the 'otaku': Rules for consuming popular culture in contemporary Japan," *Japan Forum*, 25(2). Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1080/09555803.2012.743481>.

Chambers, S.N.I. (2012) *Anime: From Cult Following to Pop Culture Phenomenon*[Preprint]. Available at: <https://doi.org/http://www.inquiriesjournal.com/articles/836/3/anime-from-cult-following-to-pop-culture-phenomenon>.

Borrelli, C. (2002). Everything anime -slowly but surely, the Japanese style of animation is gaining a foothold in America. *The Blade*, p. B6.

Lu, A.S. (2008) "The many faces of internationalization in Japanese anime," *Animation*, 3(2). Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1177/1746847708091893>.

Leonard, S. (2005) "Progress against the law," *International Journal of Cultural Studies*, 8(3), pp. 281–305. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1177/1367877905055679>.

Tezuka, O. (1963) "Astro Boy," *Poster of Astro Boy in US* [Preprint].

“Dragon Ball Z” (1989) *Dragon Ball Z poster using full colour technology*
[Preprint]. Bird Studio/Shueisha.

Rich (2016) *How I learned to stop worrying and love being otaku*, Tofugu.

Edited by A.Y.A. FRANCISCO. Tofugu. Available at:

<https://www.tofugu.com/japan/otaku-meaning/>.